
“I hope ... to see my ...
comrades march side by
side **with Union** veterans.”

LONGSTREET AT A MEMORIAL DAY PARADE, 1902

Dubbed an “old war horse” by General Robert E. Lee, James Longstreet was one of the most accomplished corps commanders of the Civil War. Serving under Lee in the east and, later, under General Braxton Bragg in the war’s Western Theater, he was instrumental in several significant Confederate victories.

A likeable character

James Longstreet was born in 1821 to a cotton planter in Edgefield District, South Carolina. He spent the first nine years of his life on his father’s plantation and earned the nickname “Pete” after the apostle Peter, for his apparent steadfast behavior. His father died in 1833 and his mother moved to Alabama. It was through her connections in that state that he obtained his appointment to West Point in 1838. Only through grit and good fortune did he graduate (54th out of 56 cadets) in 1842. Despite his academic difficulties, he was well-liked by his classmates, who included George Pickett and especially Ulysses S. Grant, who graduated a year later. His first posting was to Jefferson Barracks, Missouri, with the 4th U.S. Infantry. During this period, Longstreet courted Maria Louisa Garland, the daughter of his regimental commander. The couple were to enjoy a 40-year marriage and have 10 children. They were enslavers, though Longstreet supported the abolition of slavery after the Civil War.

In the War with Mexico in 1846–48, Longstreet was twice brevetted (given acting promotions). At Chapultepec in 1847, he was shot in the thigh while carrying the regimental standard and